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Foreword

This issue of *Musiikki* is devoted to the proceedings of Musicology in the 3rd Millenium, an interdisciplinary and international symposium organized by Sibelius Academy, Department of Folk Music, The Doctoral School of Music, Theatre and Dance, and University Consortium of Seinäjoki in collaboration with The Finnish Musicological Society and The Finnish Society for Ethnomusicology, 17th–19th of March 2010, in Sokos Hotel Lakeus, Seinäjoki, Finland.

The particular scholarly focus of the symposium was on the recent and future technological, economical, legal and aesthetic changes embedded in the production and consumption of music, as well as on the challenges these changes bring on to musicology. The totality of presentations, almost all positioned at the proximity of these important issues, provided the participants a lively, critical and intellectually high-standard venue for scholarly discussions and international networking.

Even though the variety between different approaches and topic areas on display at the symposium was wide, there were some uniting larger issues. For instance, the intellectual and cultural current we've come to call "postmodernism", still seems to offer whole new ways of looking at society, culture and history around us. Globalization, technological mediation and hybridicization all have had an impact on how we experience music around us. In this issue, Lari Aaltonen and Antti-Ville Kärjä bring up a most acute topic in their article: the case of "Pensselisetä" (Uncle Paintbrush) who enjoyed enormous media popularity for some time in Finland over a year ago. His fame, however, was not based on traditional means. Based on a carnevalistic "mistranslation" of a performance of a Syrian popular folk song *Pinsedî Zêde* by a Syrian musician Ebdo Mihemed, an anonymous YouTube-user TheKassitus "made" "Pensselisetä" so famous, that we can with good reason talk about an "internet sensation" – as I write this, the performance has been downloaded on YouTube more than 2,5 million times". Soon after the initial break into the public consciousness, Mihemed visited Finland giving performances of his music, even on Finnish national television. Aaltonen's and Kärjä's article makes an interesting case of the interlinking of music, social media and humour constructing, negotiating, and maintaining cultural representations and meanings. They also address the prominent role of YouTube as a technological platform in the mediation of music. If you want to understand what was culturally and ideologically at issue in the Pensselisetä-phenomenon, Aaltonen's and Kärjä's article is a good source to turn to.

The North in many of its meanings was one of the prominent themes in the symposium. In her article, Jenny Daniel discusses an English opera, *Swanhunter*, the libretto of which is based on the Finnish national epic, *Kalevala*. Through ethnographic observation and interviews, Daniel's intention is to elucidate the reasons why a Finnish folk epic was chosen for the story of an English opera, and some of the ways that this tale has been treated by librettist, composer

and production team to create the opera UK company, Opera North. Another presentation on "the North" reaching the pages of this journal was given by Markus Mantere, the editor of *Musiikki*. Mantere discusses the Idea of North as an aesthetic, historical and ideological category, with the help of which it's been possible to draw borders between "us" and "them", and also to establish distinctions between superficial entertainment and pure art. Using Eduard Hanslick's, Percy Grainger's and R. Murray Schafer's ideas as a source for his discussion on the North, Mantere also demonstrates how this stereotypical idea has been used as a source of prejudice towards the "other", particularly in the writings of Hanslick and Grainger.

In a more cognitive approach to music and signification, Gabriel Pareyon discusses the accelerated loss of traditional sound patterning in musics, parallel to the exponential loss of linguistic and cultural variety in a world increasingly globalized by aggressive market policies and economic liberalization. Through his presentation, Pareyon calls for composers and music theorists to explore the world of design and patterning by *grammar* rules from non-dominant cultures, and to make an effort to understand their contextual use and its transformation in order to better appreciate their symbolism and aesthetic depth. Timo Leisiö and Martin Ebeling, in turn, present the first full-scale scientific formulation of "Seeker tone theory", a theory explaining the cognitive processes related to the tonal experience of music. Based on anthropological and neuronal findings of professor Leisiö, Seeker tone theory explains the functioning of human auditory system and proposes a justification for the use of the Seeker tone as a research tool with the help of neuronal autocorrelation. Leisiö and Ebeling demonstrate how the theory can be used as the basis for typological research of syntaxes underlying any melody to be met with in human song. Colleagues working in this field in Finland are few, and I hope this international issue will help find Leisiö's and Ebeling's work the international commentators that it deserves.

In closing, let me take the opportunity to thank the organizers and financial supporters of the symposium. I also want to thank the participants who ultimately made it so – the relaxed yet scholarly rigorous atmosphere provided food for thought for us all, as well as an opportunity to meet with interesting new musicological friends. Last but not least, I will save my dearest thanks to professor Franco Fabbri, whose keynote for the symposium"What is popular music? And what isn't? An assessment, after 30 years of popular music studies" is printed here in its totality. Fabbri is one of the established scholars in popular music studies, and it is truly an honour to have his contribution to this journal. Fabbri's retrospective presentation on the development of popular music studies helps to illuminate trans-paradigmatic and cross-disciplinary evolvement of a now flourishing field of popular music studies. Popular music has not always been a legitimate object of academic study, and Fabbri's account of "how we became what we are now" is a must-read for any young scholar planning a career in musicology.

Six months after the fact, in the cold, soon-white North,

Markus Mantere

What is popular music? And what isn't?

An assessment, after 30 years of popular music studies

Franco Fabbri

"What Is Popular Music" was the title of the Second International Conference on Popular Music Studies, held in Reggio Emilia (Italy) in 1983. Iaspm (the International Association for the Study of Popular Music) already existed then, but Iaspm's Executive Committee members didn't find it inappropriate to ask scholars from many countries to reflect about "what popular music really is". Later on, it appeared that the question had found an answer: not just in the names and titles of institutions and journals, but especially in the common sense of scholars. At some point, PMS (Popular Music Studies) became a familiar acronym, indicating an interdisciplinary practice that didn't seem to need any further explication. "We all know what popular music studies are", one could hear saying. So, there came to be not only a commonsense recognition of what popular music is, but also of the dominant practices involved in its study.

However, under the thin crust of such an apparently wide agreement, magmatic currents are still moving and clashing, and emerge here and there during scholarly meetings, in blogs and mailing lists, in institutional debates. I will address a number of issues that seem to me to be related both to that surface agreement and to those deep streams of disagreement about the identity of the popular music universe.

In July 2009 Iaspm organized its fourteenth international conference, in Liverpool. I was surprised to discover that the only attendants who also had participated in the first conference, in Amsterdam (1981), were David Horn and myself. It didn't go unnoticed that many of the first-generation popular music scholars, even those who live not very far from Liverpool, didn't attend, and that others (like a few US scholars) who attended in Rome or Mexico City, didn't undertake the easier and cheaper trip to the Merseyside: I'd say that in the first couple of days this was one of the most common topics of conversation during session breaks. Some commented that international conferences had become a place for young scholars trying to promote their careers, others added that in the UK local conferences offered better focus and more convenient dates during the academic year, so those were the places where the "big ones" (or elderly ones) would go: all signs of a mature situation, very much unlike early adventurous conferences like Amsterdam or Reggio Emilia (1983), not to mention Accra (1987). Liverpool ended up being an excellent conference. And, especially, whatever the reasons for scholars in their sixties not to attend, the growth of popular music studies in the past three decades is such, that people attending the earliest conferences would be a small minority anyway. There were eighteen papers presented in Amsterdam in 1981, forty-one in

Reggio Emilia in 1983, three hundred twenty-six in Rome 2005, two hundred seventeen in Mexico City 2007, two hundred twenty-two in Liverpool 2009. It is obvious (even if there are no detailed data on the subject) that the vast majority of current popular music scholars, like the more than thousand Iaspm members around the world, are now in their thirties or forties, and weren't there when Iaspm was established and the first few conferences were held. On the other hand, there doesn't seem to exist a visible practice of popular music studies history. That's why, begging patience from those who were there from the beginning, I'll try to investigate first the origins of organized popular music studies, in the early eighties.

I have said "organized", because I am not going to dedicate more than a few paragraphs to earlier and more or less isolated attempts to take popular music as an object of study, be they (going back in time) Wolfgang Sandner's (ed.) *Rockmusik. Aspekte zur Geschichte, Ästhetik, Production* (1977); or the Chester-Merton debate and Andrew Chester's initial observation (in 1970) that "for three years rock music has been considered, both within and outside its social base, as a subject of serious critical attention" (and he added: "yet the standard of writing about rock remains poor and the major breakthrough to found a genuine rock aesthetic is still to be accomplished"); or Umberto Eco's introduction to *Le canzoni della cattiva coscienza* (Jona, Liberovici, Straniero, De Maria, 1964), and the book itself; or *On Popular Music* (1941) and other preceding and following essays by Adorno; or Duncan MacDougald, Jr.'s "The Popular Music Industry" (a study referenced by Adorno in his more famous article) in Paul F. Lazarsfeld's and Frank N. Stanton's (eds.) *Radio research 1941* (which also includes Adorno's "The Radio Symphony. An Experiment in Theory").

Each of these examples, anyway, deserves some attention, as they help revealing both the reasons why it took so long for popular music studies to find their way in research and educational institutions, and the shape they came to have.

MacDougald Jr.'s essay contains an illuminating description of what the author calls "the popular music industry". It is – of course – the music publishing industry in the US, or, better, Tin Pan Alley in the later Thirties and early Forties: which makes the essay a wonderful educational tool for those students of ours who, by "music industry", mean (with the same inflexible confidence as MacDougald in 1941, but with a different content) today's phonogram industry, and *just that*. MacDougald describes how the music publishing industry created, promoted and sold its products, almost inevitably suggesting a Fordist character in its proceedings and emphasizing the role of "plugging". Reading the essay, one is led to believe that whatever song the music publishing executives thought to be correctly 'built' aiming at commercial success would probably get it, provided the correct plugging procedures were followed. The author honestly admits that plugging sometimes did not work, and individual songs could remain unpopular, but the overall ideological atmosphere of the essay, quite understandably as it was part of an early stream of studies on 'culture industry', seems to be based on a too easy identification of the procedures of popular

music industry with those of Fordist industry. As a quotation from *The Enquirer* reveals, the music industry itself looked at the songs' competition for airplay more in the terms of a horse race than of a deterministic technological process (which also explains the later adoption of the term "disc jockey"):

> 'All the Things You Are' took first place, with 11 lengths to spare, guided by Eddie Wolpin and staff, who also spotted 'I Didn't Know What Time It Was' in third place tie for Hanry Spitzer at Chappell's. Clever work, boys. 'Who Told You I cared' grabbed place coin, handled by Norman Foley and Colleagues – Jack Robbins' staff piloted 'Lilacs in the Rain' into 6th position, while Johnny White's warriors dropped 'Can I Help It' into the 5th hole. The Santly-Joy staff upped 'Honestly' from 14th to 9th place (*The Enquirer*, December 18, 1939, quoted in MacDougald 1941, 99–100).

But this could also be seen as a way to romanticize an otherwise dull promotional work, based on strict schedules, "high pressure plugging", etc.

Adorno's reading of MacDougald's article, in his well known "On Popular Music", conforms to the Fordist interpretation. "Standardization" is the key concept, and it is very hard today to escape the suspect that MacDougald's essay was at that time the major (the only?) source of Adorno's information about the music publishing industry. In a footnote, Adorno writes:

> As the actual working of the plugging mechanism on the American scene of popular music is described in full detail in a study of Duncan MacDougald [--], the present study confines itself to a theoretical discussion of some of the more general aspects of the enforcement of the material (Adorno 1941, 447).

At least, it could be said that "On Popular Music" should be read keeping MacDougald's essay in mind. To be more explicit, we could say that one should read "On Popular Music" knowing that the information on music publishing procedures on which it is based is drawn from an essay ideologically biased to present "the popular music industry" as a modern, Fordist industry tout-court, based on standardized products (the 32 bar Tin Pan Alley song) and standardized procedures.

This is not the place for a much more articulated critique of Adorno's "On Popular Music", available from many valid sources (Paddison 1982, Gendron 1986, Middleton 1990, Robinson 1994, Krims 2003), most of which address the fact that Adorno's perception of music around him (when it wasn't "serious music") was, to say the least, ill-informed. The only addition I would allow myself is that in the whole article (except for a few hints at lyrical detail) there isn't one attempt to even the briefest musical analysis of a popular song, while there are several (albeit schematic) descriptions of pieces by Beethoven, Haydn, Wagner, etc.; all songs are described as based on a fixed 32 bar structure, and there are several repetitions of the concept that no detail of a popular song is related to the whole (as in "serious music"), and all elements are easily interchangeable. However, Adorno never wonders why Tin Pan Alley songs have an AABA structure, and not ABAA. But let me also note that many critical comments of Adorno's essays date from the early years of organized popular music studies, which is a sign of the impact that Adorno's theories had on their development.

It is well known that Adorno, one of the most respected defendants of musical modernism, was seen after the Second World War as a reliable reference for progressive intellectuals also outside the musical circles, and so his bitter and snobbish attitude towards popular music and jazz (or, as we now know, towards what he thought to represent those genres) helped create or heighten a barrier to keep them out of educational institutions. Conservative musicologists were against "light music" already. If the champion of modern music was against too, and progressive writers, playwrights, artists, philosophers, politicians would trust his implacable (and, alas, rather undialectical) criticism, who could do anything? But sometimes we tend to forget that Adorno's theories on standardization were also used *within* the popular music discourse, and I would not doubt that to a certain degree they even contributed (in a dialectical, typically Adornian fashion) to the development of popular music studies.

An example is offered by *Le canzoni della cattiva coscienza* ("Songs of/from bad conscience"), a book published in Italy in 1964, written by Michele L. Straniero, Sergio Liberovici, Emilio Jona, and Giorgio De Maria, former members of the group of singers, songwriters, poets, and writers named "Cantacronache" ("chronicle singer"), established in Turin around 1957–8, with the declared aim to "escape escapism". While the music activity of the group (which included also Margherita Galante Garrone and Fausto Amodei, and benefited from the collaboration of intellectuals like Italo Calvino, Franco Fortini, Umberto Eco and others) was influenced by French and German models (Georges Brassens, Brecht-Eisler, Ernst Busch), their critical stance was strongly shaped by some of Adorno's essays, which had been translated into Italian. Not "On Popular Music" (its first Italian translation was published very late, in 2004), but especially *Dissonanzen*, the collection of essays including "Über den Fetisch-charakter in der Musik und die Regression des Hörens", that was published in Italian in 1959, with a translation by Giacomo Manzoni (a music critic and one of the best known Italian avant-garde composers, who also wrote some music for Cantacronache). Also *Philosophie der neuen Musik* was translated by Manzoni, and published in the same year, 1959. So, it can be said that the introduction of some of Adorno's most important musical writings to Italian readers took place very close (chronologically, and even geographically) to members and collaborators of Cantacronache. The impact on Italian musicology and more in general on intellectual circles was explosive. Some of the essays in *Le canzoni della cattiva coscienza* (especially the one by Liberovici) attack the products of contemporary popular music industry with the same tones of Adorno's most contemptuous critiques of mass-distributed music. But there are two notable differences. First, songs and their arrangements are subject to a detailed analysis, though most often based on Adornian prejudices, and sometimes even turning them upside down: so, if Adorno seems to respect arrangers more than songwriters, Liberovici treats the very practice of arranging as a corrupting musical activity, quite in line with the very essential or bare accompaniments in the production of Cantacronache records. But, second, *Le canzoni della cattiva coscienza* puts forward the idea that there can be "other" songs, and that song

writing can escape the alienating machinery of the music industry, just like Cantacronache had been doing for a few years.

Umberto Eco, in his foreword, acknowledges the authors' effort to construct a critique of "gastronomic music", or "consumption song", but also acknowledges the existence of "authors, musicians, singers *who make songs differently*" (Eco 1964a, 11; italics are his) and their proposals of "'different' songs" (p. 12). Quite interestingly, Eco observes that "'different' songs require respect and interest", and so "they still represent, although within the boundaries of mass culture, a 'cultivated' option" (p. 13). What Eco suggests in the following pages is a deep analysis, without aristocratic prejudices, of so-called "consumption songs" (what we would probably call mainstream popular music), aimed not just at a destructive critique of industrial practices, but especially at understanding the basic emotional and cultural needs of those who listen to those songs. And he wonders: do "different" songs answer to those needs? So, to many respects, Eco takes a distance from the book he's asked to introduce, as can be gathered from his final sentence: "In this framework, the book by our four authors must be received as a first step (an inevitable *pars destruens*) of a discussion that we are more and more urgently prompted to continue" (p. 28). Eco's foreword was published in the same year also in his collection of essays *Apocalittici e integrati. Comunicazioni di massa e teorie della cultura di massa*, under the title "La canzone di consumo" (Eco 1964b).[1] Though the book was at the centre of an animated debate in Italian intellectual circles, and marked the beginning of a new season in mass communication studies (including amongst their objects radio, television, advertising, comics), that urgent discussion on popular music didn't actually continue.

The suggestion of oppositional practices and ideologies based on contradictions within popular music had been put forward since the early Fifties by sociologists like David Riesman (1950) or Howard S. Becker (1963),[2] sometimes with a direct critique of Adorno's theories, otherwise implicitly. Whether considering the opposition between rock'n'roll fans and supporters of Tin Pan Alley songs and crooners, or professional jazz-oriented musicians against commercial dance music, or between folk revivalists and pop singers (epitomized by the Newport "scandal" of 1965), it can be said that by the later Sixties a commercial vs. anti-commercial debate was established in its essential terms, based on the assumption (contrary to all Adorno's writings on the subject) that popular music isn't necessarily lost in the industry's greedy hands, and that it can be "saved". Eco's caveats about "different" songs remained unknown or unheard. The Chester-Merton discussion in 1970 (Chester 1970a, Merton 1970, Chester 1970b) shows how Adorno can be "used" within a discourse where the aesthetic value of popular music can be considered or even taken for granted,

[1] *Apocalypse Postponed* (Eco 1994), a collection of essays based on *Apocalittici*, with the addition of more recent material, does not include a translation of "La musica di consumo".

[2] Reference is to a collection of articles, some of which date back to the early 1950's.

and not only when Merton (quoting an earlier article) states: "Perhaps a polarization Stones/Beatles such as Adorno constructed between Schoenberg and Stravinsky might actually be a fruitful exercise" (Merton 1970). Rock vs. pop, the autonomy of the *oeuvre* vs. the context, a musicological approach vs. a cultural/sociological one, the wholeness of a piece of music vs. the analysis of its constituent parts, music analysis vs. the commentary of lyrical content, intensionality vs. extensionality: many of the key concepts of the subsequent debate are already present under the umbrella of Marxist dialectic materialism, and foreshadowed by the everlasting suggestion (by Lenin, and Mao) that "the 'people' are never a stable category: their identity is mutable and conjunctural, because they are perpetually redefined by the conflict of the classes and their culture" (Lenin, *Collected Works*, Vol. 9, 112; quoted in Merton 1970). "The familiar simplicity of the phrase ['popular music']", writes Merton, "conceals a quicksand. Who are the people?" A very good question.

Rock journalism in the 1970's avoids the quicksand (or jumps lightheartedly into it) by identifying "the people" with the young audience of rock: rock is modern popular music, rock is today's folk music (Landau 1972, 130), rock is even (in Wolgang Sandner's somehow ironic annotation) "die E-Musik der Popmusik" (Sandner 1977, 31). It's rock that deserves critical attention, also in serious essays (Laing 1970, Gillett 1970, Denisoff and Peterson 1972, Marcus 1975, Sandner 1977), because of its social and political relevance in contemporary "advanced" societies, and because of its growing musical refinement. The journal *Popular Music and Society*, founded in 1971, accepts constructively the fuzziness of both concepts, "popular" and "society", but (while there are other possible subjects that could be peripheral to the journal's interest, being scarcely popular or not being analyzed with society in their background) there is no doubt that rock be both popular and social. Sandner's pioneering collection of essays is in many respects exemplary of this climate, and at the same time anticipates some future developments: it's titled "Rock music. Perspectives about [its] history, aesthetics, production", it's published by Schott, Germany's historical music and academic publisher, it contains essays by one of the founders of modern music sociology, Tibor Kneif, and it contains transcriptions and analyses of pieces by Chuck Berry and Gentle Giant. The study of such music isn't yet admitted into the institutions, but is now knocking heavily at their gates.

But before we come to the establishment of "organized" popular music studies, we have to consider another distinct and complementary driving force, separated from those of social and cultural criticism, of rock journalism and early rock musicology, or from the demands of rock musicians and producers, in search of recognition for their increasingly complex work. I'm talking about schoolteachers, and music teachers. Schoolteachers were under the pressure of their pupils, asking explanations about the music they listened to: they felt disempowered, as most of that music was outside the range of their professional curricula. The same happened to music teachers working in schools. It is worth noting that three of the eighteen papers presented in Amsterdam in 1981 were about this subject (Tagg 1982, Josephs 1982, Straarup 1982). And there

were also independent music teachers, former or active jazz, rock, pop, folk musicians, wanting to discuss their methods with colleagues, looking for social and institutional recognition, wondering why the instruments, genres and theories they were teaching could not be introduced in conservatories or universities. In some countries this came to be a significant social movement: in Italy it brought to the establishment (in 1979) of a monthly magazine, *Laboratorio musica*, edited by composer Luigi Nono and published jointly by Ricordi (the music publisher) and Arci (the cultural and recreational organization of Italian left), which hosted some of the first studies on popular music after *Le canzoni della cattiva coscienza*.

The whole of this current was less focussed on rock, was more oriented to consider all music genres and cultures excluded from/by the academy, was sensitive to issues of localism, and (subject to ideological forces of the time) of "cultural imperialism". I suggest that these aspects have to be considered to explain why the scope of popular music studies (or research, like in the title of the 1981 conference) was then broadened to include all genres, repertories, cultures, events, excluded from academic institutions, comprehending specialized industrial products like film and tv music, title tunes, jingles, and of course music cultures from all around the world, using for them the same Anglo-American expression: "popular music".

Though I think that the "stream" metaphor shouldn't be taken without criticism, I would say that organized popular music studies were started when the more recent wave of studies (mostly based on musicology and semiotics) joined the previous stream of sociologically and anthropologically oriented studies, with the intermediation of cultural studies from the Birmingham school (based on sociology's tradition but oriented by French structuralism). Too simple, maybe, but rather apt to describe the diverse disciplinary interests of the scholars (and musicians, and teachers, and journalists, and radio programmers) who took part in the conferences on popular music research held in the early Eighties, or those who wrote articles for the newly founded journal, *Popular Music*. Anyway, there are solid traces of that confluence in the statutes of Iaspm (article 2.1):

> The aim of the Association is to provide an international, interdisciplinary and interprofessional organization for promoting the study of popular music. A guiding principle should be that a fair and balanced representation of different continents, nations, cultures and specializations be aimed at in the policy and activity of the Association.

There was no suggestion to establish a new discipline, called "popular music studies". Rather, there were hints that the study of popular music would or should change the structure of existing disciplines, especially musicology: see, for example, Richard Middleton's invitation to re-construct musical history (1985a and 1985b), or Philip Tagg's statement that what was really needed wasn't an association for the study of popular music, but an association for the *popular study of music*. Such invitations and statements were not new in

the history of musicologies: they had been central in the development of new disciplines, whenever the resistance of conservative (and powerful) scholars prevented the inclusion of new objects of study, since the creation of comparative musicology, up to the birth of ethnomusicology and of music anthropology. It must be said, however, that promises to include more music (or all music!) as the object of study of new or extended musicologies were never really kept: for a long time in the history of ethnomusicology popular music had been seen as the enemy's field, and even Charles Seeger's effort for a unitary field for musicology (Seeger 1970) excluded some music that the author didn't like! The value or taste issue, based also on a long-established Weberian tradition, may explain the inclusion in the second volume of the journal *Popular Music* of an article like William Brooks' "On Being Tasteless", and is one of the reasons why Philip Tagg's first monumental approach to an individual song (1981) is based on Abba's "Fernando" and not, say, Gentle Giant's "Design", the piece analyzed in Sandner's book (1977), both songs being from the same year, 1976:

> [--] when Mahavisnu Orchestra, Gentle Giant or similar exponents of 'difficult' rock music perform for their fans, it is questionable whether such a musical occasion should be termed 'popular', since the sociomusical function involved includes such typical sociocultural art music phenomena as peer group identification connected with notions of aesthetic superiority (Tagg 1979.)

So, the effort to define popular music, in a theoretical framework that would allow to consider differences and analogies amongst diverse kinds of music, can be seen not just as the indispensable search for the "borders" of a new research field, but also, or rather, as a way to find an objective base, to prevent that popular music studies become simply the collection of individual scholars' interests and tastes. Please allow me a brief personal remark. I'd like to point out that I don't see anything wrong in studying how values and canons are created, or how taste is formed (and how it works), in any music culture, be it European late Romanticism, heavy metal, or Kaluli tradition. And I am very much interested in the importance of these issues in what we might call metamusicology: that is, why does one choose to study Mahler, Deep Purple or the music of people living in the Bosavi region? But this is another issue. When I presented my rather primitive "theory of musical genres" in Amsterdam, a close friend of mine told me: "Fine, you are giving an overview of genres that exist, and how they work. But what is really needed is a theory to establish which genre *is the best one!*"

In view of the subdued ebullience of Adornian themes, as remnants of the 1970's rock aesthetics but also due to the incumbent presence of that stone guest in academic discourse (one of the papers presented in Amsterdam was titled "Et si l'on reparlait d'Adorno?", Beaud 1982), many of the popular music scholars active in the early 1980's distanced themselves from issues of taste and value, in various ways and for various reasons: some – like Tagg – even refrained to study music they cherished, choosing to work rather on the mainstream of transnational popular music; some warned against the hegemony of con-

ventional musicology's canonist attitude, implying that popular music studies should be more established before value-intensive genres (so to speak) like progressive or avant-rock be studied extensively. This antiaestheticist pre-emptive action was probably too severe, but it prompted useful discussions, for example on uncommercial popular music, as Umberto Fiori defined it in the paper he presented in Reggio Emilia:

> Shall we call 30,000 people listening to Anthony Braxton in Perugia a social élite? What number of listeners is necessary to enable us to speak unambiguously of the music they listen to as popular music? What number of listeners is necessary for us to regard their motivations as 'the need for better music' instead of 'the search of aesthetic superiority'? In other words, is popular music somehow defined by quantity? [--] Uncommercial popular music is still popular music. (Fiori 1985, 14.)

I remember disagreeing, at that time, both with Fiori and with the passage in Tagg's *Kojak* (the one I also quoted above) that Fiori criticized. I don't think anybody would call Anthony Braxton's music "popular music", whatever the number of its listeners (and I'm sure, having met Braxton, that he would never call it that way either): in his polemics, Fiori fell into the same quantitative trap he was warning against. And, at the same time, he was finding himself in the quicksand Merton had described, identifying Italian politically progressive youth (forming the audience of Umbria Jazz Festival in the later Seventies) with "the people". But he was right – especially in a conference titled "What is Popular Music?" – pointing out that any definition of popular music should allow for the existence of uncommercial popular music. I would also add, in partial disagreement with Tagg's ideas on the subject, that '*muso* music', the music that amateur and professional musicians like, but has a very marginal or non existent appeal on large popular music audiences, should be of great interest for popular music scholars, for the influence it exerts on very important communities in popular music making.

But let's go back to definitions. At the same time when Iaspm launched the call for papers for its second international conference (titled "What is Popular Music?"), Cambridge University Press was about to issue Volume 2 of the journal *Popular Music* (titled "Theory and Method"). This is no coincidence, of course. Many articles in that volume address the matter of music categories, relating them to methodological issues: "Analysing Popular Music: Theory, Method And Practice" by Philip Tagg (1982b), "A Theoretical Model For The Sociomusicological Analysis Of Popular Music" by John Shepherd (1982), Richard Middleton's "Editor's Introduction To Volume 2" (Middleton 1982), and my own "What Kind Of Music?" (Fabbri 1982b). A full section of the proceedings of the Reggio Emilia conference is titled "Theoretical Perspectives", and I think it to be useful to list all papers included: "What Is Popular Music?", by Chris Cutler (1985), "Popular Music: Theory, Practice, Value", by Umberto Fiori (1985), "Popular Music, Class Conflict And The Music-Historical Field", by Richard Middleton (1985), "Popularity in Music: Some Aspects of a Historical Materialist Theory of Popular Music", by Peter Wicke (1985), "A Latin-American

Approach in a Pioneering Essay", by Coriún Aharonián (1985), " The Wondrous World of Popular Intonation", by Vladimir Zak (1985), "Definition as Mystification: a Consideration of Labels as a Hindrance to Understand Significance in Music" by John Shepherd (1985), "Definitions and Research Orientation: Do We Need a Definition of Popular Music?", by Frans. A.J. Birrer (1985), "'Popular Music' in the Terminology of Communication and Information Theory", by Manfred P. Galden (1985).

Shepherd quotes an article by Gaynor G. Jones and Jay Rahn, "Definitions of Popular Music: Recycled" published in 1981 in a collection of writings on New Music (!) assembled by Gregory Battcock (other articles are by, amongst others, Earle Brown, Cornelius Cardew, Brian Eno, Nam June Paik, Steve Reich):

> There are at least twelve criteria by which one can determine the popularity of any given music: 1) number of people involved; 2) combined homogeneity and heterogeneity of audience, 3) unpredictability of listeners; 4) size of the business that markets the product; 5) efficiency (that is, breadth and cheapness) of transmission; 6) aural rather than visual transmission; 7) secular or entertainment function; 8) simplicity of the aesthetic object; 9) emphasis on performer rather than composer; 10) standardisation; 11) range of variability; 12) degree of ephemerality (Jones & Rahn 1981, 47–48).

No doubt about why Shepherd found labels as a hindrance to understand significance in music, or why Fiori suspected the presence of quantitative criteria. However, lists of criteria similar in their aspect to Jones's and Rahn's could be assembled as the unfolding of more complex descriptions of a multidimensional musical field, like the ones presented by Tagg in a graph (1982b, 42) or by myself:

> A system so examined would appear like a matrix with rows of rules and columns of genres, in which each single element a_{ij} would indicate the value of the rule i for the genre j (Fabbri 1982, 54).

A "system", in the "theory of genres" I presented in the early 1980's, was an assembly or set of genres, so the scheme could be applied to any combination of music types: sub-genres belonging to a genre; genres belonging to a music category like "art", "folk", "popular"; or categories like the former belonging to "music", intended as the assembly of all musics (music events) in the world. In fact it evolved, until very recently, from a theory of genres within popular music to a theory on music categorization, applicable to all types or kinds of music, including individual "works", which actually are – in my perspective – sets of distinct music events referred to with the same title (Fabbri 2006). It wasn't (and it isn't) a normative theory, in that norms, rules, codes (as well as prototypes, "family resemblances", etc.) defining a genre or music type must be discovered empirically, and are not based on scholars' assumptions (which are, anyway, subject to Popperian falsification); and it wasn't (and it isn't) a "static" theory, as some said (Frith 1996, Negus 1999, Santoro 2010), because the intermingling and stratification of different norms and codes, in the context of different competences and changing communities, give genres and other music categories a

fuzzy, vibrating, ever-changing quality. The aspect of that theory that most satisfied me was exactly its ability to describe how new genres could be formed, how they could be interpreted differently by different communities, how they could evolve and even disappear. What's "static" about this?

Music categories are more "folk" categories than scientific *taxa*: a kind of music, and even music itself, is defined by the people who "perform any kind of activity around any kind of sound" as Gino Stefani (1976) put it. And "music is anything a community considers as such" (Stefani, Guerra Lisi 2004, 126–127), he added, with an obvious and explicit reference to what John Cage and Luciano Berio said on this matter. This acceptance of an *emic* definition of music and its subcategories wasn't yet clear in all theories and discussions about the definition of popular music in the early phase of organized popular music studies, but it was the implicit foundation of a good percentage of the papers presented in Reggio Emilia, the ones which addressed "National and Regional Perspectives". Many of them were about non-English speaking communities, so the problem of translating "popular music" into the corresponding expressions (if any!) in other languages (or vice-versa) added complexity to the task of understanding whether a certain music culture or activity should be considered as "folk", or "popular" or whatever else. In fact, many ethnomusicologists participated in the second Iaspm's conference (second, to this respect, only to Mexico City 2007), as the question in the tile solicited them to test the "borders" of their discipline. "Musica popolare" in Italian means traditional (or folk) music, so when the graphic designer brought me his idea for the conference's poster, I wasn't too surprised to see that he had drawn a kind of six-string banjo, where the strings were stretched between a blue sky and green earth. Following my suggestions (at that point we didn't have time nor money to change the poster entirely) he added a red phone-style electric guitar cable and plug.

This can be, perhaps, a demonstration of the concept that whatever one considers to be popular music, *it is* popular music: which isn't exactly what I meant talking about "folk" categories, emic descriptions, Stefani, Cage and Berio, and so on. But it may be an introduction to the climate that followed after Reggio and its focus on definition, especially if one considers the times, places, contexts and purposes of next conferences: Montreal in 1985, the first conference in North America, after a rapid growth of Iaspm as a truly international organization; Accra in 1987, a tribute to African music in the year of the commercial "invention" of world music; Paris in 1989 (history, of course); Berlin in 1991 (should have been East Berlin, but the wall went down earlier). Had the popular studies community in the meanwhile embraced any definition of popular music? Had they accepted Shepherd's or Birrer's suggestion that definitions were an obstacle or simply were not needed? Or were they in search of new, more convincing ones?

By the end of that period, Italian young scholar Roberto Agostini (1992) wrote an article titled "Studiare la popular music" ("studying popular music") for a book edited by Gino Stefani (1992), where the results of some pioneering Italian studies were collected (they were all extracts from dissertations at the

University of Bologna, at a time when such studies were flourishing, thanks to the efforts of Stefani, Mario Baroni and Roberto Leydi). Agostini says:

> The recent discussion on the subject of popular music originated from this sort of *intuitive popular music concept*, which at a general level is substantially agreed upon, but at a deeper level reveals an outstandingly multifaceted character and prompts disagreement. Within our contemporary musical universe it is possible to delimitate intuitively a vast set of musical activities which aren't 'serious' or 'folk', ranging from punk to rock'n'roll, from reggae to hip-hop, from ambient music to commercial jingles, from film and television music to songs of any kind, reaching areas where categorization is more difficult, like jazz, progressive rock, tango, minimalism. Now, notwithstanding evident differences, we have anyway the impression of facing a certain degree of homogeneity, some common elements. Indeed, all these music activities:
>
> are not studied in public institutions (conservatories, universities, schools of any type, research institutes);
>
> take place in the context of complex activities (multimedia communication, subcultures and countercultures, background of public and private environments);
>
> circulate largely in reproduced form (mass media, records, tapes, cds, etc.) and are mainly produced in recoding studios;
>
> systematically access modern electro-acoustic technologies;
>
> are encountered every day, even when one is not willing;
>
> are generally approached in a 'distracted' mode; sometimes they aren't even 'listened to', but simply 'sensed';
>
> aren't subsidized by public money, but are based on free market;
>
> are professional activities;
>
> are widespread in modern industrialized society, where they are the music industry's more representative products;
>
> generally are not accompanied by any musical or aesthetic theory of their own;
>
> often can be found in the lowest social classes.
>
> It is this impression of homogeneity that is indicated by the expression 'popular music' (Agostini 1992, 169–170).

One can disagree radically or partially with each of Agostini's points, but to do him justice I must say that the above "intuitive concept", so articulated, is precisely what Agostini in the following part of his article criticizes and deems to be obsolete, or in need of a much more refined articulation. As he suggests, however, it is a very good snapshot of the situation at that time (1992) in that place (Italy), or an expression "of the feelings of researchers who in the Seventies had an interest in musics that public institutions continued to ignore" (Agostini 1992, 171).

But let's now turn to a much more recent effort to give a similar discursive definition, in Roy Shuker's "Introduction" to his *Popular Music. The Key Concepts*:

> The term 'popular music' defies precise, straightforward definition [--] In one sense, popular music encompasses any style of music that has a following, and would accordingly include many genres and styles that are largely excluded from this volume, most notably the various forms of classical music and jazz. Obviously, the

> criteria for what counts as popular, and their application to specific musical styles and genres, are open to considerable debate. Record sales, concert attendance, numbers of performers, radio and television air play, are all quantifiable indicators of popularity, but classical music clearly has sufficient following to be considered popular, while, conversely, some forms of popular music are quite exclusive (e.g. death metal) [--] For the purposes of this study, I have largely followed conventional academic practice, equating 'popular music' with the main commercially produced and marketed musical genres, primarily in a Western context. I am conscious that this emphasis is open to charges of ignoring many significant forms of popular music, located primarily in non-Western settings, *but boundaries were necessary to make the project viable*.[3] Further, Western styles of popular music continue to dominate the international market place, at the same time appropriating local music styles [--] Accordingly, the emphasis is on traditional 'rock' and 'pop' forms, and their various derivative styles/genres, along with more recently prominent genres such as rap, 'world music' and the various styles of dance music (Shuker 2005, xii–xiii).

A rather vague description for a book bearing that title! An excellent book in many respects, however, if one considers the Anglophone academic readership at which it is aimed. There is a "popular music" entry, of course, where the author duly (and very briefly) reports about "various attempts to provide a definition" (most of them from the early 1980's, amongst the ones I discussed extensively above), having noted however that "difficulties lead some writers on popular music to slide over the question of definition, and take a 'common-sense' understanding of the term for granted" (Shuker 2005, 203–204).

I sympathize with Shuker, but I don't see much progress with respect to the description of "the feelings of researchers" given by Agostini thirteen years earlier, and his "intuitive popular music concept".

The key concepts here (I apologize for any unwanted irony) are: "conventional academic practice", "quantifiable indicators", "Western context", "international market place". And they are inevitably ideologically loaded, because (for example), academic practice in English-speaking countries may differ greatly from that of Latin American, or Nordic, or Central European, or Southern European, or Middle Eastern, or African, or any other academic practice on popular music in countries different from the UK, Ireland, Canada, USA. And quantifiable indicators are subject to the same criticism raised by Fiori more than thirty years earlier (though the matter of uncommercial or "niche" popular music practices is reported by Shuker, in his annotation about death metal: maybe not the most uncommercial of uncommercial popular music that one can think about). The Western context is, of course, a choice. But even within such an ethnocentric perspective, does the West include just English-speaking countries? Aren't Brazil, or Argentina, or Mexico or Cuba westerly enough? Isn't Greece part of Western civilization? Or Russia? And remaining within strict quantitative criteria, which international market place are we talking about: are we considering the millions of copies sold of each successful single or album by popular artists in Egypt, or India? Do figures about the Arabic record market or live performance business belong to the international market place? And if not, why?

[3] Italics are mine.

There is something odd in the currently common concession that "this position can be accused of ethnocentrism, but...", and that "but" is generally followed by good or very excuses (like "within the scope of this study", or "otherwise the size of this book would be excessive", and so on). It makes us feel nostalgic of good old ethnocentrism, that didn't need to give explanations. However, like in the case of Agostini, we know that Shuker can't be accused for reporting the common-sense of his own time, and place. And he is quite right when he says that "some writers on popular music" were led "to slide over the question of definition". I would argue: much more than just some. I have searched through the programmes of the three most recent international conferences organized by Iaspm (that I attended: in Rome, Mexico City, Liverpool), and I was able to find just nine papers, out of a few hundreds, addressing (in various ways) problems related with a definition of "popular music", all of them from the 2005 Rome conference (none from 2007 or 2009): three by Italian scholars, two by French scholars, two by Canadian scholars (one of them being actually English, or Swedish: Philip Tagg), one by a US scholar, one by a Norwegian scholar. Obviously, this is also the sign that popular music studies are a mature interdisciplinary "field", and that scholars and students are now focussing on more detailed subjects, some of which actually transcend the 'boundaries' of Western 'conventional academic practice'.[4] But do we really know what popular music studies are? Or is this an expression equivalent to "conventional academic practice"? And anyway, what are the risks involved in undervaluing definitional issues? Let's face them, to conclude, one by one.

The socio-conceptual issue: what is "the people", and what is "popular"?

One of the reasons why the expression "popular music" was chosen to label a distinctive "field" of study was the polysemy of the adjective "popular" in English, and of corresponding adjectives in other languages. "Appealing to many" and "belonging to the people" are meanings that no other expression vehicles so efficiently at the same time: "media music", or "mediatized music", or similar equivalents do not account for "grassroots" activities that many scholars see as essential to a definition of the music they study; and any effort to describe the latter aspect fails to account for the music's industrialized production and mass distribution. Quantitative ("positivist") and essentialist definitions are incompatible, but "popular" (the adjective) does the trick quite well. Richard Middleton commented at length this issue in the first paragraph (titled "What is popular music?") of his book, *Studying Popular Music* (Middleton 1990, 3-7), drawing on the taxonomy of definitions suggested by Frans Birrer in his paper for Reg-

[4] When I use terms like 'field' and 'boundary', they have to be interpreted within a multidimensional space. That's why I put them between quotes, meaning that they don't have to be understood as literal metaphors of a bi-dimensional space.

gio Emilia (Birrer 1985), and preparing the ground for the introduction of the concept of 'articulation':

> [--] in class society, the *society* is internally contradictory. What the term 'popular music' tries to do is to put a finger on that space, that terrain, of contradiction – between 'imposed' and 'authentic', 'elite' and 'common', predominant and subordinate, then and now, theirs and ours, and so on – and organize it in particular ways (Middleton 1990, 7).

Relations between culture and society, or better, between cultures or subcultures and the social groups within which they are developed, are contradictory, not deterministic, and they change with time. Stuart Hall wrote:

> Today's rebel folksinger ends up, tomorrow, on the cover of the *Observer* colour magazine. The meaning of a cultural symbol is given in part by the social field into which it is incorporated, the practices with which it articulates and is made to resonate. What matters is *not* the intrinsic or historically fixed objects of culture, but the state of play in cultural relations: to put it bluntly and in oversimplified form – what counts is the class struggle in and over culture. (Hall 1981/2006, 484.)

History: that's where the principle of articulation, that Middleton draws from Hall, and Hall from Gramsci, is situated. And Middleton traces in history (especially in the history of British and US popular music) changes in the meaning of "popular". But what about changes in the meaning of "the people", as suggested (via Merton) by Lenin and Mao (who were both much less popular in 1990 than in 1970, I'd say)? Middleton quite rightly relates a shifting of the meaning of "popular" to changes in the meaning of "the people", for example under the pressure of democratic ideologies (since the American revolution), but I would argue that a certain degree of autonomy exists also between the noun and the adjective: "people" has meanings that can't be easily transferred to "popular", and vice-versa. Just think of the official tone of "the people" in political or juridical discourse, for example. Not to mention the populist drift that both the noun and the adjective have been subjected to (independently) in many countries, in the twenty years that separate us from Middleton's reflections on the subject. We might even wonder if that polysemy is still at work, and if it's still worth exploiting. But this aspect takes us to the next issue, the linguistic issue.

How does the expression "popular music" translate into other languages? Although it is clear that many communities of scholars accepted to use the English expression anyway, how do "local" terms (like música popular, musica popolare, populäre Musik, musique populaire, musique de varietés, etc.) affect the perception of this/these "kinds of music"?

To answer these questions, first of all, one should be able to trace the development of the concepts and meanings of "the people" and "popular" in each language, in each culture, in each nation's history. There are some hints about this aspect both in Hall and in Middleton, but it must be said that a homogeneous development across cultures is not to be taken for granted. I am not raising any charge of ethnocentricity here, but of course one cannot expect that the concept of "people" has been the same and has evolved in parallel fashion even within nationalist Europe. Just pronouncing the German word "Volk" (especially if preceded by an article: "ein Volk") makes me think of "the people" with a shiver. And the meaning of "popolo" today still has connotations related to the usage of the word during Fascism. Only few days ago the Italian right-wing government proclaimed the celebration, every year, of a "Giornata nazionale della musica popolare", where "musica popolare" doesn't mean popular music, nor even traditional or folk music (as Italian ethnomusicologists have called it for decades), but the music of brass bands, of folkloric music and dance groups, and everything related to the usage of folklore by Mussolini in his age. And how is Silvio Berlusconi's party named? "Popolo della libertà", of course. In Italy, "musica popolare" never had a modern meaning: left-wing parties, whenever they tried to regulate public funding of music activities, including popular music, used the expression "musica popolare contemporanea",[5] but "musica popolare" still suffers of the official distinction made during the Fascist rule between "musica leggera" (light music) and "musica popolare" (folk music). The English expression "popular music" is used in universities and in some conservatories, and by a few journalists (specially younger ones, who attended courses in universities or read academic books on the subject), but the adoption of that conventional label cannot compensate for the lack in Italian of an equivalent common-sense expression of any kind: neither "musica leggera", nor "musica di consumo", nor "musica mediatica", etc. So I often wonder how different it has to be for an Italian popular music scholar or student to think about his/her own object of study, compared to a British or US colleague, who doesn't see any distance, any fault, between the conventional field of study and a common-sense concept rooted in language and culture since almost a century. And I think that this kind of conceptual schizophrenia affects many non-Anglophone scholars. That's why we (I mean, the non-Anglophones) ask so many, maybe too many questions on the subject. Like the following.

[5] Even very recently, for a regional law on music activities in Tuscany.

The ethnocentric vs. multicultural issue: is popular music just the Anglo-American pop-rock mainstream? What is 'world music', then?

I have dealt with this issue already. So, I will add just a few considerations. My personal ethnography (that is, participating in many conferences on popular music, lecturing in Anglophone countries, corresponding with friends, discussing in mailing lists) suggests to me that for many colleagues, especially in the USA, it is almost inescapable to think of popular music as "American popular music" (of course, other colleagues have objected for years to the use of the continent's name to indicate an individual country, but I will not comment any further on this). Or, "American popular music" plus the Beatles and what followed. Often I have the impression that some people think that referring to tango, or timba, or French chanson, or Greek *néo kyma*, with the expression "popular music" be an act of political correctness, that can be dispensed of when talking "amongst us". And music that any good effort to define the popular music concept would recognize as popular music from other countries, is called by many "world music". Although the expression "world music" as a genre label is probably of British origin (Frith 2000 reports it to have been adopted by English record producers in July 1987, but Peter Gabriel was using it months before),[6] it resonates with the concept of "the world" being "not us", that was at the base of the hymn "We Are the World", a hit in 1985 (re-enacted recently for Haiti). It appears to be a special act of generosity to say that "we" are the world: usually, "they" are the world.

"World music", of course, has many meanings (anyone can say: "We all know what world music is!"). No musicological police can prevent communities from using genre labels as they wish. Even when members of the "Canterbury scene" (one of the sub-genres of progressive rock) never happened to live or perform in Canterbury. But the scholars' community is a special one. It was a good choice, I think, that of referring to genre labels as they emerge from, so to speak, genres themselves. But, I would suggest, at a distance. Before being a matter of multiculturalism, it is a matter of scholarship. Explore common-sense; look for its structure, its networks; relate it with observable facts, with texts, performances, music events; relate the emic with the etic: these are the basics, I think, of any music study. But then, at least two other aspects of popular music's "academic common practice" need to be shortly commented, again.

[6] "I go into many record stores and I see, as well as a reggae section, there's an African music section, and in five or 10 years I hope there will be a world music section." Peter Gabriel, interviewed by Ray Hammond, *Sound on Sound*, Vol. 2, Issue 3, January 1987.

The "modern media" issue: is popular music just media-related music? What about nineteenth century fado, Stephen Foster's Ethiopian songs, "classic" Neapolitan song? What makes "media music" popular? And is the concept of "media", accepted when the expression "popular music" was adopted, still valid now?

I had to ponder these questions in the past ten years or so, when I was asked by Italian publishers to write short, and later less short, accounts on the history of popular music. And, at the same time, when I was appointed to lecture at the University of Turin about the same subject. Where to start? Which genres to include? How to locate popular music chronologically and geographically? I followed various criteria (that I exposed throughout this paper), and decided to use the beginnings of the music publishing industry as a reference. There, in the age of the bourgeois and industrial revolutions, are the roots of the differentiation and displacement of music categories – like physical forces after the Big Bang – that gave room for a new one, popular music (though, but this is quite common in such historical processes, it received a name only decades later). But then, I had to think of definitions of popular music which give sound recording a great importance, identifying media with mechanic or electronic means of producing, distributing and reproducing sound, and at the same time implying that most popular music is not notated. What was, then, the music sold in millions of printed copies before Edison's invention or while the phonograph was still a device to dictate letters in offices? Like "Funiculì funiculà" (1880) or "After the Ball" (1892)? And if Adorno in 1941 (quite rightly, I think) called "music industry" the music publishing industry, shouldn't we think of the media as a more articulate category, or even abandon the concept at all, as it is unable to account for the heterogeneity of phenomena as diverse as music printing and social networks?

And finally, the "popularity" issue: is popular music just any kind of mainstream? Does "unpopular popular music" really exist?

These questions are more delicate than they seem. "Niche" popular genres exist, any popular artist wasn't popular when he started, and the activity of very many amateurs or would-be stars is essential to any definition of popular music, even if the vast majority of them will never achieve any kind of success, even locally, and will never even record their music. But this doesn't mean that any "niche" genre or any music activity that hasn't a large following (how much?), and that happens to be not studied institutionally, be "unpopular popular music". Like Anthony Braxton in Fiori's polemic example. I think that popular music studies cannot carry the load of all music that is not studied by

conventional musicology, ethnomusicology, jazz studies, although this was, in their early years, a very powerful glue. On the other hand, I think that there is some responsibility, and pride, amongst popular music scholars, to have pointed out that a great part of music activities on the planet wasn't covered, until only thirty years ago, by academic music studies, and still wouldn't, if it hadn't been for those "serious young men and women with goatee beards and glasses" meeting in Amsterdam in 1981, as reported by the *New Musical Express* (and commented by Tagg 1982b). And that responsibility remains, as we point out that until a unified "field" of musicology is established, many relevant human activities with and around sound will fall in the gaps between disciplines, and will not be dealt with by any. This is a reasonable, and not impossible, task for musicology in the years to come.

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